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Mobile phones have
also become a source
of entertainment

Network NATTER

From the fisherman on the high seas to the vegetable vendor on the street to the businessman in his high-powered office, the mobile phone has become the medium of the masses and the great equaliser

■ By Sunil Bharti Mittal

The mobile revolution is less than a decade-old but one doesn't have to go very far back in history to witness the rationing of telephones. In the early '90s, one waited for years for a phone connection. Today, as more than seven million mobile customers enter the networks every month, the long wait seems a distant memory. For me, this explosive telecom growth encapsulates India's transformation into a resurgent economic

power. My tryst with the telecom sector began as a telephone manufacturer in the mid '80s, when handset manufacturing was opened to the private sector for the first time. But mobile telephony was different. Growth was sluggish. It took three years for the mobile subscriber base to cross the million-mark in 1998 and it was tough for operators. Out of the 25 early entrants, only three survive. Most of them sold out, a few collapsed, and some merged